



Honduras



Area 43,278 sq miles
(112,090 sq km)
Population 7.8 million
Capital Tegucigalpa
Currency Lempira
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 70 years



Honduras is a mountainous country lying between Guatemala and Nicaragua. It has a small southern coastline facing the Pacific Ocean and a much longer shoreline on the north facing the Caribbean Sea. It is the second-poorest country in Central America, with about 60 percent of the population living below the national poverty line.

Cuba



Area 42,803 sq miles
(110,860 sq km)
Population 11.3 million
Capital Havana
Currency Cuban peso
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 78 years



The Republic of Cuba is the largest island in the Caribbean Sea. Cuba has three mountainous regions—the Sierra Maestra, the Sierra de los Órganos, and the Sierra de Trinidad. Fertile lowlands are used for farming sugarcane and rice. Cuba has been

Nicaragua



Area 49,998 sq miles
(129,494 sq km)
Population 5.9 million
Capital Managua
Currency Nicaraguan córdoba
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 72 years



Nicaragua lies in the heart of Central America. The country is divided into three geographical zones: Pacific lowlands; cooler, wet central highlands; and Caribbean lowlands. About a third of the population lives in the capital, Managua. Indigenous Miskito tribes and descendants of African slaves live mainly along the Caribbean coast.

Panama



Area 30,193 sq miles
(78,200 sq km)
Population 3.6 million
Capital Panama City
Currency Balboa and US dollar
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 75 years



Panama is the southernmost of the seven Central American countries. Deforestation threatens Panama's rainforests, which cover about 40 percent of the land. Since 1999, Panama has had full control of the Panama Canal, which connects the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans and is a major international shipping route.

a one-party Communist nation led by Fidel Castro since 1959. In 2008, his younger brother Raúl Castro took over the reins. Living standards in Cuba fell dramatically in the early 1990s, when Communist Eastern Europe—previously Cuba's main trading partner—collapsed. Since then, the number of people trying to leave has risen markedly.

► CLASSIC CARS IN HAVANA

Cars dating back to the 1950s dot the streets of Cuba's capital, Havana. Taxi services offer tours in these classic cars, which are well maintained and in excellent condition.



Bahamas



Area 5,382 sq miles
(13,940 sq km)
Population 300,000
Capital Nassau
Currency Bahamian dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 73 years



The Commonwealth of the Bahamas is an archipelago (a stretch of water containing many islands) of 700 islands and islets. It sits to the northeast of Cuba in the western Atlantic. Two-thirds of the population live in the capital city of Nassau, on New Providence island. The Bahamas is a popular destination for vacationers.



▲ DASHEEN

A root vegetable, dasheen is a staple crop cultivated in Jamaica. Its leaves are often used to make a popular breakfast dish called callaloo, which is enjoyed throughout the Caribbean.

Jamaica



Area 4,243 sq miles
(10,990 sq km)
Population 2.8 million
Capital Kingston
Currency Jamaican dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 71 years



Jamaica is an island in the Caribbean Sea, located 90 miles (145 km) south of Cuba. Most Jamaicans are of African descent, with small Indian, Chinese, and European minorities. Jamaican music is famous the world over. The musical styles of ska, ragga, and reggae originated in the poverty-stricken districts of Jamaica's capital, Kingston.